According to experts, if a nation is going for economic planning it must have ‘perspective’ element in it. To have perspective in planning, two basic elements need to be fulfilled, namely—

(i) Planning should be evaluation-based, and

(ii) ‘long-term’ goals should be followed up besides the ‘short-term’ goals.

In the Indian content, the succeeding plans have been always commenced without the full evaluation of the preceding Plan. This was mainly due to following reasons:

(a) Lack of a nodal body responsible for data collection at the national level;

(b) Federal nature of polity made data collection full of delays and also due to higher dependence on the states; and

(c) Speedier data delivery was not possible.

After the recommendations of the National Statistical Commission (Chaired by C. Rangarajan), 2000, the Government discussed to set up a nodal body for data collection at the pan-India level, cutting across federal hurdles. Computerisation is already being done for speedier data delivery. For the time being the Plans are launched on the basis of projected data (provisional, latest, etc.) which is almost near the real data. But once the above discussed arrangements are in place, Indian planning will be based on evaluation, undoubtedly. In the meantime, the ‘Quarterly Review’ and the ‘Performance Budgeting’ of the Union Budgets have brought in the evaluation element to a greater degree./

The First Plan had set long-term goals (for the coming 20 years) besides the short-term goals (for five years). But over the time, falling confidence in mobilising required resources and political uncertainties at the centre made it a convention to set only short-term targets of planning. This shortcoming seems to be done away with after the commencement of the Tenth Plan. The Plan did not go for setting long-term goals only but even did set monitorable targets for the Eleventh Plan, too.

Point should be noted here that the Government had been conscious about the need for perspective planning as a separate Division with the same